The nature of things

> Sublime Lucretius's work will not die,
> Until the day the world itself passes away.
>
> – Ovid[13]

I often think that the loss of the works of Democritus in their entirety[fn2] is the greatest intellectual tragedy to ensue from the collapse of the old classical civilization. Take a look at the list of his works in the footnote; it is difficult not to be dismayed, imagining what we have lost of the vast scientific reflections of antiquity.

We have been left with all of Aristotle, by way of which Western thought reconstructed itself, and nothing by Democritus. Perhaps, if all of the works of Democritus had survived, and nothing of Aristotle's, the intellectual history of our civilization would have been better …

But centuries dominated by monotheism have not permitted the survival of Democritus's naturalism. The closure of the ancient schools such as those of Athens and Alexandria and the destruction of all the texts not in accordance with Christian ideas were vast and systematic, at the time of the brutal anti-pagan repression following from the edicts of Emperor Theodosius, which, in 390–1 declared that Christianity was to be the only and obligatory religion of the empire. Plato and Aristotle, pagans who believed in the immortality of the soul or in the existence of a Prime Mover, could be tolerated by a triumphant Christianity. Not Democritus.

But a text survived the disaster, and has reached us in its entirety. Through it, we know a little about ancient atomism and, above all, we know the spirit of that science. It is the splendid poem *De rerum natura* (*The Nature of Things*, or *On the Nature of the Universe*), by the Latin poet Lucretius.

Lucretius adheres to the philosophy of Epicurus, a pupil of a pupil of Democritus. Epicurus is interested more in ethical than scientific questions and does not have Democritus's depth. He sometimes translates Democritean atomism a little superficially. But his vision of the natural world is substantially that of the great philosopher of Abdera. Lucretius decants in verse the thought of Epicurus and the atomism of Democritus, and in this way a part of this profound philosophy was saved from the intellectual catastrophe of the Dark Ages. Lucretius sings of atoms, the sea, the sky, of nature. He expresses in luminous verse philosophical questions, scientific ideas, refined arguments.

> … I will explain by what forces nature steers the courses of the sun and the journeyings of the moon, so that we shall not suppose that they run their yearly races between the heaven and earth of their own free will … or that they are rolled round in furtherance of some divine plan …[14]

The beauty of the poem lies in the sense of wonder which pervades the vast atomistic vision – the sense of the profound unity of things, derived from the